Pre-Modern Perceptions

Before the nineteenth century, India and China had limited contact but had respectful views of each other. The high point of contact was when Buddhism thrived in China. This was followed by a period of some Indian kingdoms paying tribute to the Chinese court: the relationship was reversed, and Indians looked up to China. With the coming of the European colonial powers to India, the relationship between the two societies came increasingly to be mediated through imperialism, and from it developed a Chinese attitude of disdain towards India.

China Looks Up to Buddhist India

While Buddhism first came to China from Central Asia and Iran, not directly from India, the golden period of India–China interactions resulted from Chinese Buddhist pilgrimages to northern India, starting in the fourth century CE and extending up to about the eleventh century CE. The flow of influence was not all one way. Chinese Buddhist ideas and practices flowed back to the land of the Buddha, but it is fair to say that India was looked on as the *Madhyadesha* or Middle Kingdom.

The origins of the relationship

As every Indian schoolchild learns, the Chinese Buddhist monks Faxian and then Xuanzang came to India in the fifth century and seventh century, respectively. They are the best-known chroniclers among Chinese visitors, but hundreds of other Chinese monks and pilgrims came to India to venerate and to learn. The great era of Chinese pilgrimage came to an end in about the eighth century, though Chinese inscriptions discovered at Bodhgaya are dated as late as the eleventh century.[1] When Central Asia passed out of the hands of the Chinese, making travel difficult, and possibly also as a result of the decline of Buddhism in India, the pilgrimages ended.